THE JACKSON HEIGHTS BEAUTIFICATION GROUP PRESENTS



IN CELEBRATION OF THE 100TH ANNIVERSARY OF
TRINITY LUTHERAN CHURCH
OF LONG ISLAND CITY & ASTORIA

JACKSON HEIGHTS ORCHESTRA

Wednesday, May 20, 2026, 7:30 P.M.
Trinity Lutheran Church
Astoria, NY

ALEX WEN, *Artistic Director*

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PROGRAM

Overture in C Major — **Fanny Mendelssohn-Hensel** (1805–1847)

Cognōscent (v23) — **Michael A. Lee** (b. 1975)

World Premier

Commissioned by the Jackson Heights Orchestra

I. Prelude
II. Media Vita
III. Militans Scurrilis
IV. Chorale Mortis
V. Kenosis Purificans
VI. Benediction

Symphony No. 5 in D Minor, Op. 107. "Reformation" — **Felix Mendelssohn** (1809–1847)

I. Andante. Allegro con fuoco
II. Allegro vivace
III. Andante
IV. Andante con moto

CHURCH CELEBRATION

Trinity Lutheran Church building is 100 years old!

And we welcome you.

We are so pleased to have our friends of the Jackson Heights Orchestra to celebrate this milestone.

Enjoy the concert.

Pastor Paul

NOTES ON THE PROGRAM

Overture in C Major (1832)
Fanny Mendelssohn-Hensel

Fanny Mendelssohn Hensel's Overture in C Major is one of those pieces that makes you wonder what we lost because the 19th century was so wrong about women.

Born into the brilliant Mendelssohn family, Fanny was every bit as musically gifted as her younger brother Felix. A formidable pianist, composer, conductor, musical organizer, Fanny was also the gravitational center of an extraordinary artistic circle in Berlin. Unlike Felix, she was not encouraged toward a public career. She composed over 300 lieder and piano works, performed largely in private salons, not on the concert stage.

The Overture in C Major is her only surviving orchestral work. This delightful piece has spurred efforts in recent years to uncover and share more of her original works. Probably written between 1830 and 1832, the Overture in C Major was discovered over 100 years after her death.

Opening with a sense of poise and expectancy, the music quickly reveals her understanding and grasp of orchestral color, structure, and drama. There is brightness, but also muscle; grace, but also momentum. It is the work of a composer who knew exactly what she was doing and, more importantly, knew exactly what she wanted the orchestra to do.

The piece moves with the clarity and sparkle associated with the Mendelssohn sound world: quicksilver strings, buoyant rhythms, lyrical wind writing, and a kind of controlled exuberance that never spills into chaos. But Fanny's voice is not an echo of Felix's. Her writing has its own confidence, architecture, and dramatic pacing. She balances Classical elegance with Romantic energy, giving the overture both polish and pulse.

What makes this overture especially compelling is not only its musical quality, but its historical presence. The Overture in C Major gives us a tantalizing glimpse of what Fanny's public orchestral voice could have become had she been granted the same opportunities afforded to her brother. Still, this piece is not a footnote. It arrives with energy, craft, and elegance, making its case in the most convincing way possible: by being excellent. *—Melissa Minkow*

NOTES ON THE PROGRAM

Cognōscent (v3) (2026)
Michael A. Lee

I was invited to write a piece specifically for this program, sandwiched between Fanny and Felix. As I marinated for a bit in both pieces, I reflected on the history of the Christian faith and the Christian church, and the ways in which these are sometimes in conflict.

Cognōscent builds on two primary motifs: one poses a question, the other proposes an answer. The first is drawn from the 13th-century chant *Media Vita in Morte Sumus* (In the midst of life we are in death), asking, “How should we who are dying then live?”

The second movement offers one possible answer: the Church Militant seizing political and cultural power, in the face of mortality, building kingdoms here on earth. But the pursuit grows both buffoonish and menacing, and the attempt ultimately fails to resolve.

It decays into the *Chorale Mortis*, a woodwind choir developing the *Media Vita* until it finally yields a different answer: the three-note motif (E–G–A) first introduced by the high bassoon in the prelude of the piece. Derived from the folk hymn "They Will Know We Are Christians by Our Love,” the motif repeats and repeats relentlessly in the low brass and strings, insistent even as the harmony stretches into bitonality and pulls the keys farther and farther apart.

Through all that harmonic instability, one anchor holds: *They will know. They will know. They will know we are Christians by our love.*

How shall we who are dying then live? By love.

—Michael A. Lee

NOTES ON THE PROGRAM

Symphony No. 5 in D Minor, Op. 107. "Reformation" (1830)
Felix Mendelssohn

Felix Mendelssohn was only 20 when he embarked on his "Reformation" Symphony. It was intended for the 300th anniversary of the Augsburg Confession, a defining document of Lutheran theology presented in 1530. This incredibly soulful, rich, and symbolic music painted a canvas: faith, conflict, tradition, renewal, and, naturally, a few glorious wind passages that make woodwind players' ears tingle and the brass section feel like it's Christmas over and over again.

Although numbered as his Fifth Symphony, the "Reformation" was actually one of Mendelssohn's earlier symphonic works. The numbering does not reflect when it was composed; rather it is related to publication history. Mendelssohn completed the piece in 1830, but it was not published until after his death.

The symphony opens with a solemn, church-like introduction, including the famous "Dresden Amen," a rising liturgical phrase associated with church services and later made even more famous by Wagner in *Parsifal*. Mendelssohn uses it not as an accent, but as an entire theme. It builds the atmosphere of ceremony, reverence, and historical memory all at once. From there, the first movement breaks into a fiery Allegro, full of urgency and contrapuntal drive. It is dramatic, liturgical, amazing. Close your eyes when you listen. You will feel it.

The second movement brings contrast. Nimble, bright, and classically balanced, it is less debate and more sparkle. The third movement turns inward, singing with lyrical restraint. This is the kind of movement where the oboes get to remind everyone that a single well-shaped line can do more emotional damage than an entire brass section.

The finale brings the symphony's central symbol into full view: Martin Luther's chorale *"Ein feste Burg ist unser Gott":* "A Mighty Fortress Is Our God." Mendelssohn introduces the tune with incredible simplicity before rapidly growing it into a grand orchestral statement. The chorale is melody but it is also the blueprint—building, getting stronger, until it ends with full resolution.

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NOTES ON THE PROGRAM

For all its historical and religious associations, the “Reformation” Symphony is also a deeply musical act of transformation. Mendelssohn turns inherited musical elements like chorale, amen, counterpoint, and ceremonial nods in to something very personal.

In short, this is Mendelssohn collecting the building materials, designing the architecture, and erecting the cathedral all in a beautiful, dramatic, and faithful music. It carries us forward and moves us at the same time.

—Melissa Minkow

ARTIST BIOGRAPHIES

Alex Wen, Artistic Director of the Jackson Heights Orchestra, is a conductor with deep roots in the New York City music community. He has served as assistant conductor with the Massapequa Philharmonic and Park Avenue Chamber Symphony and spent five seasons as Principal Conductor of the Golden Rose Opera, where he led productions of La Bohème, Carmen, Suor Angelica, Cavalleria Rusticana, and Madama Butterfly. His commitment to new music has brought him to contemporary ensembles including PinkNoise Ensemble and NYsoundCircuit, and he has premiered works by Eric Moe and Huang Ruo with Fresh Squeezed Opera.

Alex also worked with Rhymes With Opera, Queens College Orchestra and Opera, Litha Symphony Orchestra, Sound Symphony Orchestra, New Amsterdam Symphony Orchestra, and the All-County Festival Orchestra of the NMEA, as well as engaging as cover-conductor for the Brooklyn Symphony Orchestra, Queer Urban Orchestra, and Yonkers Philharmonic. Alex holds a Master’s in Orchestral Conducting from the Aaron Copland School of Music, where he studied under Maurice Peress, and a Bachelor of Music in viola performance from Azusa Pacific University. He participated in the 2019 Cabrillo Festival for Contemporary Music Conductors Workshop.

ARTIST BIOGRAPHIES

Wenqi Li is a Queens-based music educator, flutist, and conductor. She currently teaches music at Saint Ann's School in Brooklyn. Throughout her career, Wenqi has taught everything from elementary general music to choirs, concert bands, and marching band. She especially loves teaching middle school band and directing musical theater productions. She studied music education and flute at The Ohio State University with Katherine Borst Jones.

Wenqi has played flute with the Jackson Heights Orchestra since 2013. A member of the JHO Leadership Committee, she also serves as Assistant Conductor, under the mentorship of Alex Wen. In her free time, she sings in the church choir and the Astoria choir at Trinity Lutheran Church. She is very grateful for this opportunity to celebrate Trinity's centennial with both her musical and church families!

Michael A. Lee is a keyboardist and composer living in the Los Angeles area. His work has been performed by the BBC Orchestra, The Pittsburgh Symphony, The New York Philharmonic String Quartet, The British Youth Opera, and the Hollywood Bowl Orchestra, as well as in hundreds of films and TV shows. He has worked as an orchestrator and arranger with Sir Elton John, Danny Elfman, The Queen's Master of Music Judith Weir, Gospel Music legends Richard Smallwood and Shirley Caesar, and was commissioned to build a custom electronic instrument for composer Philip Glass. The *Los Angeles Times* once referred to him as "also on the program." He currently serves as Director of Commercial Music at Azusa Pacific University.



ORCHESTRA MUSICIANS

Artistic Director
Alex Wen

Assistant Conductor
Wenqi Li

Violin I
Susan Metcalf, Concertmaster
The Chad Tindel and Sonia Kuchuk Chair
Adeena Emery
James Leddy
Christian Lee
Qiyao Pan
Diane Ye
Siyi Zhang

Violin II
Louise Lau, Principal
Barbara Freed
Rex Gayas
Ana Melo
Lynette Pettinicchi
Jennifer Sloan

Viola
Mary Ellen McNamee, Principal
Molly McNally
Ania Upstill
Heather Wallace

Cello
Patricia Edens, Principal
Lauren Bailey
Sheryl Reed
Rachel Santamaria-Schwartz
Hasina Torres
Diana Wayburn

Double Bass
Eli Naragon, Principle
Darren Lipper

Flute
Hannah Donnelly
Barbara Novick

Oboe
Melissa Minkow
David de la Nuez

Clarinet
Matt Brauner
Alice Petre

Bass Clarinet
Brandon Helrich

Bassoon
Shira Calamaro
Ezra Gans

Contrabassoon
Aaron Goler

French Horn
Michael Cohen
Kaleb Lewis
Charity Morrison
Genevieve Scandone

Trumpet
Julia Cohen
Chad Tindel

Trombone
Greg Genova
Anthony Santiago

Bass Trombone
Phil Fletcher

Percussion
Fred Trumpy

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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SPECIAL THANKS TO

Our Lady Queen of Martyrs Church
Wenqi Li: Assistant Conductor
Patricia Glunt: Emeritus Artistic Director
Assemblywoman Catalina Cruz for her grant to the JHBG
Shekar Krishnan: City Council member
Genevieve Scandone and Wenqi Li: Program Book

And a special thanks to all the members of the orchestra!

For more information or to join the JHBG go to www.JHBG.org.

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SUPPORT THE JACKSON HEIGHTS ORCHESTRA

Jackson Heights Orchestra concerts are made possible only with donations from audience and community members. We are running a fundraising drive to raise money for the 2026–2027 season, and we would love to have your support!

1. **Silver Strings - $50** You're playing a major part! Get a mention in our concert program and on our website.
2. **Golden Brass - $100** Receive a souvenir program from one of our signature concerts, autographed by our conductor. This souvenir program is a tangible reminder of the music and its story.
3. **Platinum Percussion - $250** Receive a souvenir poster from one of our signature concerts, autographed by our conductor. Also includes all previous rewards.
4. **Concertmaster's Companion - $500** Join us for a special behind-the-scenes look at one of our concert dress rehearsals and receive early entrance to our concert the following day. Experience the passion and hard work behind each performance firsthand. All previous rewards included.
5. **Maestro's Circle - $1,000** You'll be invited to a private meet-and-greet with our conductor and a few select musicians. Share in our love for music and learn about the heart of our performances. Includes all previous rewards.
6. **Orchestra Insider - $5,000** Delve deeply into the orchestra's world with this tier. You and a guest will be invited to join us for a special dinner with the conductor and select members of the orchestra, where you'll get to chat about music, our journey, and the future of Jackson Heights Orchestra. All previous rewards included.
7. **Symphony Sponsor - $10,000** Sponsor a concert! Your name or business will be prominently featured as a main sponsor for one of our concerts. Receive accolades during the concert's opening and also be presented with a special plaque of appreciation. Includes all previous rewards.

To make a donation to the JHBG in support of the Jackson Heights Orchestra, please visit our website at https://jhorchestra.org/donate or use the QR code below:

OUR MISSION

The Jackson Heights Orchestra (JHO) is dedicated to enriching and elevating the dynamic cultural landscape of the Jackson Heights community through its live performances. Our ensemble is composed of musicians from diverse backgrounds, united by a shared passion for music-making. We are committed to providing an inclusive and supportive environment where our musicians hone their skills, collaborate, and continue their artistic journey.

ABOUT THE JHO

The Jackson Heights Orchestra (JHO) was established in 2012 by founding Music Director Patricia Glunt in collaboration with the Jackson Heights Beautification Group (JHBG). During her tenure from 2012 to 2023, Glunt grew the ensemble to be one of the premiere orchestras of Queens. The JHO is proud to be a program of the JHBG and to serve the Jackson Heights community. Visit jhorchestra.org to learn more.

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SAVE THE DATE!

Don't miss our exciting concert Sunday, July 5, at 6 P.M., kicking off the Concerts in Travers Park 2026 Season, sponsored by the Jackson Heights Beautification Group. Led by our Assistant Conductor Wenqi Li, the program will be a pops concert featuring marches, movie themes, and popular tunes!